

Session 2 – Getting Ready

Your AWS Setup Guide

Welcome! Before our first cloud computing live session, this short guide helps you create your own Amazon Web Services (AWS) account and switch on two simple safety nets, so you can learn with complete peace of mind. It takes about 15–20 minutes and assumes no prior experience. Just follow the steps in order.

Everything we build during the bootcamp uses resources that are free, and the steps below make an accidental charge effectively impossible. By the end of this guide, you'll be ready to deploy your first cloud application in Session 2.

What you'll need

Item	Details
An email address	One that you have not already used to register for AWS.
A mobile phone	To receive a one-time verification code by text or call.
A credit or debit card	Used only to confirm your identity – see the note below. You will not be charged for bootcamp work.
About 15–20 minutes	And a computer with a web browser (Chrome, Edge, Firefox, or Safari).

“Will I be charged?” The short answer: NO.

When you sign up, you'll choose the Free plan. On the Free plan you receive \$100 in free credit, and AWS will not bill your card, If you ever went past the free limits, AWS simply pauses the account instead of charging you. AWS asks for a card only to confirm you are a real person, exactly like many free trials do.

On top of that, the \$5 budget and the usage alerts you'll set up below give you an early warning long before anything could ever cost money.

Part 1: Create your AWS account (Free plan)

Follow these steps in the sequence provided.

NOTE: AWS updates its sign-up pages from time to time (and sometimes by geographic location). If a screen looks slightly different from the description (AWS updates its sign-up pages from time to time), look for the button or field with the closest matching name.

Step 1: Start sign-up and enter your account information

- Open <https://signin.aws.amazon.com/signup> in your browser (or go to aws.amazon.com and choose "Create an AWS Account").
- **Root user email address:** enter your email. The "root user" is simply the main owner of the account (that's you).
- **AWS account name:** type a name you'll recognise, for example "YourName Bootcamp". You can change this later.
- Choose **Verify email address**. AWS emails you a verification code, type it in to continue.
- Create a strong password and confirm it. Keep it somewhere safe, this is the master key to your account.

Why this matters

The email and password you set here are your account's main login. Use a password you don't use anywhere else.

Step 2: Choose the Free plan

- During sign-up, AWS asks you to choose between a Free plan and a Paid plan.
- Choose the **Free plan**. For everything we do in the bootcamp, the Free plan is all you need.

Free plan vs Paid plan

The Free plan gives you up to \$200 in credits (\$100 right away, plus up to \$100 more for trying a few services) and lasts up to six months. Crucially, it will not charge you. If the credits run out, the account simply closes rather than billing you.

The Paid plan, by contrast, begins charging at normal rates once your credits are used up. For a learner, pick Free.

Step 3: Add your contact information

- Select **Personal** account (unless you are signing up for a business).
- Enter your name, country/region, address, and phone number.
- Read and tick the box to accept the *AWS Customer Agreement*, then choose **Continue**.

Step 4: Add a payment method

- Enter your credit or debit card details and billing address, then choose **Verify and Add**.
- AWS may place a small temporary authorisation (often around \$1) just to check the card is valid. This is reversed automatically — it is not a charge.

Why this matters

This is only an identity and validity check. On the Free plan your card will not be billed for the bootcamp work.

Step 5: Verify your identity (phone)

- On the *Confirm your identity* page, choose to receive your code by **Text message (SMS)** or **Voice call**.
- Select your country code and enter your mobile number.
- Enter the CAPTCHA characters shown on screen, then submit.
- AWS sends you a code (or calls you). Enter the PIN and choose **Continue**.

Step 6: Choose a Support plan

- On the *Select a support plan* page, choose **Basic support — Free**.

Why this matters

Basic support is free and is all a learner needs. The paid support plans are designed for companies running production systems.

Step 7: Finish and sign in

- You'll see a confirmation that your account is being activated. This usually takes a few minutes but can take up to 24 hours; you'll get a confirmation email when it's ready.
- Once activated, open <https://console.aws.amazon.com/>, choose **Root user**, and sign in with the email and password from Step 1. This is the **AWS Management Console** (your control panel for everything).

Security tip

Treat your root login like a bank password and never share it. For extra safety you can later turn on multi-factor authentication (MFA) from the Security credentials menu, but it is optional for the bootcamp.

Part 2: Set up a \$5 monthly budget

A budget is a simple spending limit that emails you if your costs ever approach it. We'll set a low **\$5 monthly budget** as an early-warning tripwire. Bonus: setting up a budget is also one of the activities that can earn you a \$20 AWS credit.

- Sign in to the console, then open the Billing and Cost Management console at <https://console.aws.amazon.com/cost-management/> (or type "Billing and Cost Management" in the top search bar).
- In the left navigation pane, choose **Budgets**.
- Choose **Create budget**.
- Under **Budget setup**, choose **Use a template (simplified)**, this is the quick, beginner-friendly option.
- Under **Templates**, choose **Monthly cost budget**.
- Set the budgeted amount to **5** (USD), give the budget a name such as "Bootcamp \$5 limit", and enter your email address under **Email recipients**.
- Choose **Create budget**.

Even simpler option

In the same template list you'll also see Zero spend budget, which emails you the moment your usage goes beyond the always-free limits. If you'd prefer the most cautious setting, choose that instead of (or in addition to) the \$5 budget.

Why this matters

With the template, AWS automatically emails you when your actual or forecasted spend reaches your limit, so you'd hear about any cost long before it mattered.

Part 3: Turn on Free Tier usage alerts

This second safety net is different from the budget: instead of watching dollars, it watches how much of each service's free allowance you've used, and emails you as you get close. AWS turns these on by default for most new accounts, but it's worth checking.

- Open the Billing and Cost Management console at <https://console.aws.amazon.com/costmanagement/>.
- In the left navigation pane, choose **Billing preferences**.
- In the **Alert preferences** section, choose **Edit**.
- Tick **Receive AWS Free Tier usage alerts**.
- (Optional) In **Additional email address**, add another email if you'd like alerts sent somewhere else too.
- Choose **Update**.

Why this matters

AWS will email you when your usage of a free service reaches about 85% of its free limit, giving you plenty of time to react before any charge could occur.

Part 4: You're protected: how it all fits together

You now have three layers of protection working together:

- **The Free plan itself** as your card cannot be billed for bootcamp work; if a limit is ever exceeded, the account pauses rather than charging you.
- **Your \$5 budget** emails you if costs ever head toward \$5.
- **Free Tier usage alerts** email you as you approach any single service's free allowance.

Where to keep an eye on things

- The **Free Tier** page in the Billing and Cost Management console shows your usage and your remaining credit balance.
- AWS also emails you periodically about your remaining credit and how much time is left on your Free plan.

If you ever get an alert email

- **Don't worry** it's a heads-up, not a bill. On the Free plan you won't be charged.
- If it mentions a specific service, sign in and stop or delete anything you created outside the lessons.
- Bring the email to our session and we'll look at it together.

Checklist before Session 1

Tick these off so we can start building straight away:

- ☐ My AWS account is created on the Free plan.
- ☐ I can sign in to the AWS Management Console.
- ☐ A \$5 monthly budget is set up with my email address.
- ☐ Free Tier usage alerts are turned on.
- ☐ I received the account-activation confirmation email.